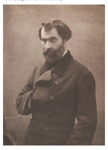
Performing Identity

0:04 / 6:04 1x

Nadar (Gaspard-Félix Tournachon)



Nadar (Gaspard-Félix Tournachon). *Eugène Pelletan*. 1856–59. Salted paper print from a glass negative, 9 3/8 × 6 3/4" (23.8 × 17.3 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Samuel J. Wagstaff, Jr.

No one explored notions of celebrity and portraiture more exhaustively during the nineteenth century than French photographer Gaspard-Félix Tournachon, known as Nadar. This delicately toned salted paper print picturing the writer, journalist, and politician Eugène Pelletan is substantial in size, expertly printed, and possibly unique. Nadar, who opened his Paris studio in 1854, also ran a thriving business making small cartes de visite for his clients—most of them members of the Parisian elite.

August Sander



August Sander. *People of the Twentieth Century. The City. Traveling People: Fair and Circus*. 1926–32. Gelatin silver prints, each approx. 10 × 7" (25.4 × 17.8 cm) or the reverse. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of the family of August Sander. © 2020 Die Photographische Sammlung/SK Stiftung Kultur - August Sander Archiv, Cologne/ARS, NY



August Sander. *Girl in Fairground Caravan*. 1926–32. Gelatin silver print, 10 3/16 × 7 3/8" (25.8 × 18.7 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of the family of August Sander. © 2020 Die Photographische Sammlung / SK Stiftung Kultur - August Sander Archiv, Cologne / ARS, NY

August Sander created an ambitious portrait of the people of the 20th century. Though the photographic project was never completed, its most comprehensive form is over 600 photographs divided into seven volumes and nearly 50 portfolios. Sander began to conceive of the structure for this work in the mid-1920s, dividing the images into seven groups that incorporated at least forty-five distinct portfolios, each representing a distinct subsection within German society. The first of these groups, "The Farmer," anchored the project with portraits made or commissioned in the rural community of the Westerwald region in Germany. Sander titled the subsequent six groups "The Skilled Tradesman," "The Woman," "Classes and Professions," "The Artists," "The City," and "The Last People" (which depicts old age, sickness, and death). Once Sander had identified his broader ambition, he sought out sitters who could function as both individuals and types, and he carefully aligned his designations with the way his subjects identified themselves.

Judith Joy Ross



Judith Joy Ross. *Senator Robert C. Byrd, Democrat, West Virginia (Majority Leader)*. 1987. Gelatin silver printing-out-paper print, 9 5/8 × 7 11/16" (24.5 × 19.6 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Shirley C. Burden. © 2020 Judith Joy Ross

In 1986 and 1987, Judith Joy Ross made a portrait series of members of the U.S. Congress and their staff. Curator Susan Kismaric included a number of Ross's photographs in an exhibition at MoMA called *American Politicians: Photographs from 1843 to 1993*. In the exhibition catalogue, she wrote, "Ross had gone to Washington with a mix of emotions—hoping that the camera would objectify her subjects and in turn identify some truths about them, and simultaneously wishing that her previously held ideas about who was 'good' and who was 'evil' would be confirmed. To her surprise, instead of an either/or record of good or evil, she came away with a series of portraits of very human beings."

Akram Zaatari



Akram Zaatari. *After They Got the Right to Arms. Fourteen young men posing with guns*. Early 1970s/2006. Gelatin silver prints, each 11 5/16 × 11 5/16" (28.8 × 28.8 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2020 Akram Zaatari

These photographs are part of a larger project in which the artist Akram Zaatari has explored the archive of photographer Hashem El Madani. From 1948 to 2008, Madani operated a photography studio in Saida, Lebanon, where he produced hundreds of thousands of photographs—mostly studio portraits. Zaatari's presentations of Madani's portraits—in this case photos of men posing with guns—the images become as much about the ever-shifting personal, historical, artistic, and economic value of photographs as they are about the individuals pictured, whose names are unknown to us.

Stephanie Syjuco



Stephanie Syjuco. *Cargo Cults: Head Bundle*. 2013–16. Pigmented inkjet print, 40 × 30" (101.6 × 76.2 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2020 Stephanie Syjuco. Courtesy of the artist and Catharine Clark Gallery, San Francisco

Stephanie Syjuco is interested in challenging notions of authenticity—in her case, as an immigrant to the United States, what it means to be "an authentic Filipino." In her series Cargo Cults, Syjuco references nineteenth-century ethnographic studio portraiture taken by travelers, who captured their subjects in "exotic" dress. She tries on fictional identities, assembling "ethnic"-looking costumes from garments and objects purchased and returned to popular retail stores at American malls including Urban Outfitters, Target, and Forever21. Syjuco makes it difficult to visually locate a singular subject in each portrait through her use of geometric patterns and through the presence of grey scale color charts that slyly offer a standard against which to measure the skin tone of the figure in the photograph.

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Seeing Through Photographs

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Module 4
One and Another

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Module 6
Pictures of People

Part I: Introduction
- Introduction to Module 6 — Reading • 2 min
- Artwork Spotlight: Katy Grannan's Portraits — Reading • 2 min
- Katy Grannan on Taking Portraits — Video • 3 min

Part II: Between Subject and Object
- Exploring Agency — Reading • 4 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Hear More: Susan Meiselas on Carnival Strippers, 1973–75 — Video • 5 min
- Self-Possession — Reading • 4 min

Part III: Individuals and Types
- **Performing Identity** — Reading • 7 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Hear More: Akram Zaatari on After They Got the Right to Arms. Fourteen young men posing with guns, early 1970s/2006 — Video • 6 min
- Hear More: Stephanie Syjuco on Cargo Cults, 2013–16 — Video • 2 min

Part IV: Strangers and Friends
- Loved Ones — Reading • 7 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Hear More: Tina Barney on Sunday New York Times, 1982 — Video • 1 min
- Hear More: Deana Lawson on Roxie and Raquel, 2010 — Video • 1 min
- Hear More: Maria Antelman on Puzzlers, 2020 — Video • 4 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • 30 min
- Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
- Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min

Module 7
Ocean of Images